D'var Torah on Parshas Terumah: Building the Dwelling Within

Introduction: Mapping Our Journey Through Shemos

Okay, so here we are, Parshas Terumah of Sefer Shemos.

Before we go too far into the Parsha itself, let's just take a recap and understand where we are within Sefer Shemos.

Sefer Shemos begins with a general premise. We are going through an adventure in an organized way. What does it mean to be a Jew? What are the middos of a Jew? What does it represent? How is it represented?

At the very beginning of Sefer Shemos, we talk about the hardship that Klal Yisrael went through—the slavery in Egypt, the oppression. We talk about the birth and growing up of Moshe Rabbeinu, the makos, the plagues, everything that led to redemption.

From there, we transition into halacha, into a little bit more activity, more structure. And now here we are talking about building the Mishkan, the Tabernacle.

The Three-Part Structure of Shemos

Sefer Shemos itself can actually be divided almost into three separate parts, for those who have been following along. I love the number three. It's good. It's represented almost everywhere, especially within Judaism.

We talk about chazakah, things being established after three times. The Gemara in Bava Metzia (106b) teaches that three creates a presumption, a pattern that has weight. We wait until a child is three years old for upsherin, the first haircut. There are different types of structures that revolve around three.

The first four parshiyos—Shemos, VaEira, Bo, Beshalach—talk about what it means to become a people, as a grouping. The hardship, the wonders, the miracles, everything witnessed as a nation. The journey from slavery to freedom, from bondage to standing at the sea.

The next two parshiyos—Yitro and Mishpatim—bring Matan Torah, the giving of the Torah, and then Mishpatim, grounded human interaction and relationships. The spiritual heights of Sinai followed immediately by the practical laws of how we treat each other.

And then from here, from this point through the end of the Sefer—Terumah, Tetzaveh, Ki Sisa, Vayakhel, Pekudei—we're talking about building the Mishkan, about becoming an

actionable people. About taking everything we've learned and experienced and building something tangible, something physical that houses the Divine presence.

It's a natural progression: identity, revelation, and then action.

The Meaning of Terumah

It's a great opportunity to jump into the Parsha itself, Parshas Terumah.

The word Terumah itself is amazing. Depending on how it's translated, one part of it can mean a contribution. I am contributing to the building of the Mishkan.

But we also know that within halacha, we have an entire masechta, an entire tractate of Gemara, around Terumot. Different gifts. The gift-giving that goes with being a Jew.

Whether it's for that larger grand audience, meaning giving the gift to Hashem to help build the Mishkan, or whether it's part of Terumot and Ma'asrot, the gifts to the Leviim, the Kohanim, all these different gifts that we separate from our produce.

These different gifts really start to make up this next section of the Torah. Because giving, contributing, elevating the physical for a spiritual purpose—this is what defines us as a people.

V'Shachanti B'Tocham: Within Them, Not Within It

The pasuk says at the very beginning of this week's Parsha (Shemos 25:8): "ועשו לי מקדש ושכנתי בתוכם," Make for Me a sanctuary and I will dwell within them.

Rashi points out something crucial: It does not say "within it" (b'tocho), but "within them" (b'tocham). Not within the building, but within the people.

Sefer HaChinuch (Mitzvah 95), Seforno (on this pasuk), and others speak about the Mishkan, explaining that the original purpose and goal behind it was not just to build a physical building, not just to create a structure of wood and gold and fabric.

Klal Yisrael, going through the human experience in Olam HaZeh, this physical world, is meant to build a dira b'tachtonim, a dwelling place for Hashem in this lowest world. But it's supposed to be within us. Within each person. Within the nation as a collective.

The Mishkan is a model, a blueprint, a physical representation of what we ourselves are meant to become.

We have to ask ourselves: Why within us? And what do we do to make that tangible? How do we become dwelling places for the Divine?

Putting Others First: The Path to Elevation

As we spoke about in earlier parshiyos, especially in Sefer Shemos, we talked about the experience of putting others in front of ourselves, that higher value and that more core focus. In Parshas Yitro, we discussed kavod. In Parshas Mishpatim, we explored how interpersonal mitzvos elevate us spiritually.

We as human beings, we as Klal Yisrael, can either be self-serving, small-minded, closed-in people. Or we can be people who give, who contribute, who elevate.

This is why we also have halachos like the minimum shiurim, minimum measurements. For example, the Mishnah in Terumot (4:3) discusses that your terumah must be at least a certain minimum amount. There is that minimum volume to make sure that you are not being a miser, not being stingy.

You shouldn't be that small person who is selfish and self-serving and ego-driven. And even if you struggle with that tendency, with that yetzer hara, let's make sure it doesn't destroy you as an individual. Let's create boundaries and minimums.

But beyond that, when we put others first, when we put Hashem first—we've spoken about this in other parshiyos as well—when that which Hashem loves, I love, and I reflect it by being like Him, then I become elevated.

The Gemara in Shabbos (133b) teaches: "זה קלי ואנוהו," This is my God and I will beautify Him—meaning, beautify yourself before Him in mitzvos. But the deeper interpretation is: be like Him. The thirteen middos of Hashem (Shemos 34:6): "ה' ה' א-ל רחום וחנון ארך אפים ורב חסד," Hashem, Hashem, God, merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abundant in kindness.

If I am acting with those middos, then I am operating on a higher level of terumah, a higher level of giving and elevation.

If I am doing those highest levels, I'm able to make it that I, my body, my soul, everything about me serves a higher purpose. I get to be the Mishkan. I become the dwelling place for Hashem's presence.

The Kodesh HaKodashim and the Human Brain

As we also learn, further explained in Masechta Yoma (21a), when they discuss the structure of the Beis HaMikdash, they talk about the Kodesh HaKodashim, the Holy of Holies, which is also built in this week's Parsha.

From sifrei Kabbalah, particularly in Chassidic teachings, we learn that the Kodesh HaKodashim corresponds to the moach, the brain. The seat of intellect, understanding, and connection to the Divine.

And the reason is because we learn from the Gemara (Yoma 21a) that the Kodesh HaKodashim was measured twenty by twenty amos, cubits.

And the Aron, the Holy Ark, which fit inside of it, was two and a half amos long and one and a half amos wide (Shemos 25:10).

But here's the miracle: there were also ten amos of empty space on each side of the Aron. The measurements of the room, when you added up the Aron and the space around it, exceeded the physical dimensions of the Kodesh HaKodashim.

The Aron did not take up space. Or more accurately, the space itself was somehow beyond physical limitation. The Gemara records this as one of the ten miracles that occurred regularly in the Beis HaMikdash.

We can also think about that from the human brain perspective. Physically, the brain is a limited organ, a few pounds of tissue. But conceptually, intellectually, spiritually? We can take in everything. We can absorb infinite knowledge. We can contain infinite wisdom. Everything can be within us.

When we treat our bodies right, when we treat our neshamot right, when we treat our brain correctly—when we use our minds to learn Torah, to think holy thoughts, to contemplate Hashem's greatness—then from this we become elevated. We get to connect back into the inyan of Zechus Avos, the merit of our forefathers. We tap into something that transcends physical limitation.

The Reality of Human Need

But unfortunately, Klal Yisrael wanted something external. They wanted to be able to point somewhere else, not just point inside.

This is the human condition. We struggle with the abstract. We want the tangible. We need to see, to touch, to have something physical to focus on.

From there we see that in the end, they wanted something physical, something separate. Not just the internal Mishkan of the soul, but an actual building. And Hashem, in His infinite wisdom and compassion, accommodated that need.

We also see other items reflected in this week's Parsha that highlight this tension.

For example, the keruvim, the cherubim. The Torah commands (Shemos 25:18): "ועשית שנים כרבים זהב," And you shall make two keruvim of gold.

From a perspective of avodah zarah, of idolatry, it's very questionable. The keruvim are angelic in nature, and normally we are absolutely not allowed to make molten images of heavenly beings. The second of the Aseres HaDibros forbids this (Shemos 20:4): "לא תעשה לך פסל וכל תמונה," You shall not make for yourself a graven image or any likeness.

Yet here Hashem is commanding it. Commanding us to make images of angels, to place them on the cover of the Aron in the holiest place in the world.

There is a higher reasoning and a higher understanding. The keruvim represent the relationship between Hashem and Klal Yisrael. When we are close to Hashem, the keruvim face each other. When we are distant, they turn away. They are a barometer of spiritual connection.

But it is also reflective of our limitations. If I am not going to be the Mishkan myself, if I am not able to maintain that level of internal holiness constantly, then I am making a decision, acknowledging that I am not on that level. I am not going to be the angel. I need the physical reminder, the external structure, the tangible representation.

The Danger of Confusion: Foreshadowing the Golden Calf

Where that later harms us is in the later Parsha, the Chet HaEgel, the sin of the Golden Calf.

Because of confusion. Because of human error. Because it is so easy to forget and to confuse ourselves.

We were told to make keruvim, angelic forms in gold. So when Moshe doesn't come down from the mountain when expected, when panic sets in, the people think: we'll make another golden form, an intermediary, something to represent the Divine presence.

The line between holy representation and avodah zarah becomes blurred in the moment of crisis.

To think: I am supposed to be the Kodesh HaKodashim. I am supposed to be gifting everything to Hashem. But I am a human being. I am limited. I am flawed. I need help. I need something external.

It is once again a reminder why we have Parshas Mishpatim after Matan Torah. We are human beings in this world. We have a human experience. We need direction. We need structure. Physicality is the way we are designed.

We cannot even say we were designed wrong or flawed, even if it may feel that way sometimes. Because that design is exactly what Hashem wanted. He created us as physical beings with spiritual potential, not as angels or pure spirits.

It's hard. It's painful at times. It's definitely not easy. But it is reality. And it gives us the ability to overcome, to say: I am going to be more. I am going to elevate. I am going to use this physical body and this physical world to create something holy.

In Our Generation: Returning to Terumah

Especially in this era, in this time frame, where we do not have the Beis HaMikdash, where we do not have the Mishkan standing physically, we get to step back to Terumah. We get to return to the essential message.

It's about giving. It's about gifts. It's about elevation.

If I want to make it that Hashem has a dira b'tachtonim here in this world now, if I want to bring about the Beis HaMikdash HaShlishi, the third Temple, so many people talk about needing it, davening for it, longing for it.

But Parshas Terumah reminds us: "ושכנתי בתוכם," I will dwell within them.

Even in our current generation, without the physical structure, Hashem can dwell within us. We can become the Mishkan. We can create that dwelling place through our actions, our middos, our relationships, our avodas Hashem.

The Connection to Purim: Priorities in Giving

We have also entered Chodesh Adar. We are preparing for Purim.

I had the zechus, the privilege, to sit in on a shiur being given daily at our shul by Rabbi Yaakov Frager, going through Hilchos Purim and discussing Matanot La'Evyonim, gifts to the poor, and Mishloach Manot, sending portions to friends.

And it reminded me of something. A pattern I see every year.

People love to overdo Mishloach Manot. Elaborate packages, beautiful presentations, creative themes, competition to see who can make the most impressive delivery.

And people love to look at the minimum halachic measure of Matanot La'Evyonim. What's the least I can give and still fulfill the mitzvah?

But if I go back to this week's Parsha, the Torah says (Shemos 25:2): " דבר אל בני ישראל ויקחו לי תרומה מאת כל איש אשר ידבנו לבו תקחו את תרומתי," Speak to the Children of Israel and they shall take for Me a terumah, from every person whose heart moves him you shall take My terumah.

"Asher yidvenu libo"—whose heart moves him. It's deeper. It's stronger. It's not about meeting a minimum. It's about the heart being aligned properly.

If my heart is aligned properly, if my priorities are in the right place, then I get to be the Mishkan. I get to be the dwelling place for Hashem.

What does that look like on a level of terumah, of giving?

It's not just a contribution, checking off a box. It's a matanah, a gift, given with love and intention.

And I am going to put the evyon, the poor person, first. Because Hashem loves Klal Yisrael, the rich and the poor equally, without distinction.

The Gemara in Bava Basra (9a) teaches: "כל המרחם על הבריות מרחמין עליו מן השמים," Whoever has mercy on people, Heaven has mercy on them. And I am going to show those who are poor that I love them too, that they matter, that they are valued.

That becomes my true terumah. That is building the Mishkan within me.

Mishloach Manot goes to friends, people who already know I love them, relationships that are already established and comfortable.

Matanot La'Evyonim is the deeper level. It's giving to people who might not be my social circle, who might not be able to reciprocate, who need to feel valued and seen and loved.

If my prioritization is correct, and I truly want the Beis HaMikdash HaShlishi, then my terumah becomes a genuine gift, not an obligation.

And that doesn't mean I neglect my existing relationships, my Mishloach Manot to friends. But it means I elevate properly. I put first things first.

Elevation of the Physical

We get to elevate the simple worldly things we have received along the way and build something bigger and more beautiful out of them.

The materials of the Mishkan were ordinary: gold, silver, copper, wood, fabric, animal skins, oil, spices. But when given with the right intention, when used for a holy purpose, they became the dwelling place of the Divine.

The same is true for us. Our ordinary actions, our daily interactions, our simple gifts—when done with the right kavannah, with the right heart, they become holy. They become part of building the Mishkan within ourselves and within the world.

Reflection and Growth

I'd like to give us all a few moments to reflect.

As we make our plans for Mishloach Manot and all the fun and joy of Purim, maybe we reflect on how we are going to give even more to Matanot La'Evyonim to make others feel loved and valued.

On Becoming the Mishkan:

- What am I doing to become the Mishkan myself?
- What am I doing to become the Beis HaMikdash in this world?
- Am I treating my body and neshama as a dwelling place for the Divine, or just as a vehicle for my own desires?

On the Keruvim:

- What do I need the keruvim to remind me of?
- Where do I need external structures and reminders because I am human and limited?
- How can I use physical mitzvos to elevate rather than confuse?

On Measurements and Boundaries:

- This week's Parsha goes into the fine rules, the exact measurements of building the Mishkan. Measurements matter. Details matter.
- When I understand measurements, I understand boundaries and limitations, for myself and for others.
- Where am I respecting the boundaries of the other Mishkanot in my life?

Every single person has a Kodesh HaKodashim and an Aron within it. Every person has an inner sanctum, a holy space that transcends physical limitation.

And I do not know what is happening inside that person, what exceeds the space I see from the outside. I don't know their struggles, their greatness, their inner world.

Just as the Aron didn't take up space, just as there was more inside the Kodesh HaKodashim than the physical measurements could contain, so too every person contains infinity.

Closing Thought

Parshas Terumah teaches us that the purpose of all our physical actions, all our giving, all our building, is to create a dwelling place for Hashem—not out there in some distant structure, but within us.

"V'shachanti b'tocham"—I will dwell within them. Within each of us. Within all of us together.

May we merit to become true dwelling places for the Divine, to give with hearts that are moved, to elevate the physical into the spiritual, and to see the Beis HaMikdash HaShlishi built speedily in our days—both the internal Mishkan within each soul and the external structure that will stand in Yerushalayim.

Have an amazing Shabbos.